



FITNESSWISE

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What is athlete readiness and how to monitor it

An athlete's potential can be **truly unlocked** by understanding the science of readiness assessment for optimal performance.

"Set realistic goals, keep re-evaluating, and be consistent" — Venus Williams.

Assessing athlete readiness is a widespread practice in most sports, for both team and individual disciplines, and can be defined in many ways. Simply put, it indicates how prepared an athlete is for competition and training sessions.

Fitness and fatigue are two key factors to be considered after an individual athlete completes a physical session. Each session comprises a chronic load, to which athletes respond differently. Here is where the assessment of athlete readiness mainly comes into play.

Training load can be categorised into two factors: internal and external. Internal load pertains to how an athlete responds to the workload, while external load refers to what the athlete actually ends up doing on the field. Both internal and external loads help determine when the athlete is prepared to engage in training or skill sessions, incorporating specific testing protocols.

Methods of readiness assessment

There are numerous methods available to assess athlete readiness, which can be categorised as follows:

- Overall fitness or wellness questionnaires
- Heart rate indices and variability protocols
- Salivary markers (e.g. testosterone to cortisol ratio)

- Blood markers (e.g. blood creatine kinase)
- Neuromuscular fatigue (e.g. Countermovement jump)
- Cortisol content in the sweat can be an effective marker

Concentrating solely on a single specific variable data will not give an accurate picture and can have a serious impact on the performance domain of athletes.

Let's examine the pros and cons of each method of collecting variable data and zero in on collective inferences to understand an athlete's readiness:

— Fitness or wellness data can be very useful due to its swift processing and affordability. However, it relies on the POV of athletes, which can lead to inaccuracies if they provide inaccurate information.

— It's important to establish individual profiling for each athlete. This establishes a genuine baseline for comparison based on their unique parameters. Relying on team averages or generic cutoff values